

SPECIAL EDITION OF THE MACHINE: SIGNAL, SOURCE, AND SECONDARY HARM

A media-structure analysis of the April 9, 2026 MS NOW Sascha Riley article, anchored to verifiable article-facing text, publication context, and continuity with The Machine.



TROY BARILE
APR 09, 2026

[Survivor Resources](#)

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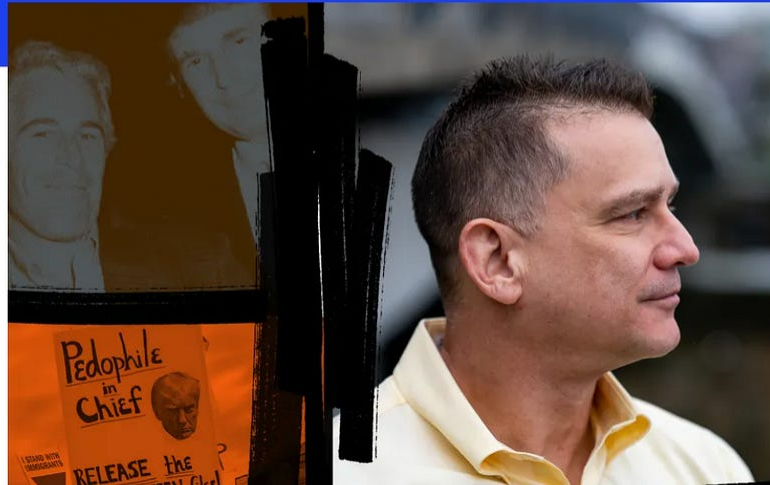
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News

The conspiratorial left needed proof Trump is a monster. They settled on Sascha Riley.

An Iraq War veteran “unlocked” new memories of abuse by Jeffrey Epstein and the right-wing elite. A network of conspiracists took control of his fantastical story.



The article arrived as a piece of reporting and functioned as narrative enforcement.

There are pieces that widen a record and pieces that narrow one and the recent MS NOW article on Sascha Riley narrows. It arrives with the conclusion already in place and uses the rest of the piece to stabilize it. The opening pages do the work that the rest of the article depends on. Riley is introduced through public comments at local meetings, then through the line that anyone who looks him up will find a “sprawling and outlandish story,” and then through the flat declaration that outside Riley’s testimony there is no evidence any of it happened. By the time the article reaches biography, memory, family conflict, or social media, the interpretive frame has already been locked. The reader is not being asked to weigh a record but to inhabit an attitude toward the record.

That is why the piece should not be read only as an article about one person because it is also an article about what kind of person is allowed to be legible in public at all. Riley is not treated as someone whose claims fail at a particular point of proof but as the center of a culture of belief that the article wants the reader to recognize as a type. The label arrives quickly as the article places his audience inside “BlueAnon,” pairs his supporters with QAnon believers, and presents the community around him as a left-wing conspiracist congregation that has packaged narrative, targeted innocents, and helped create the same post-truth atmosphere it claims to oppose. **Once the story is operating at that level, the subject no longer has to be disproved in full because the ecology around him has already been assigned its place.**

“Outside of Riley’s testimony, there is no evidence any of it happened.”

“If the right-wing conspiracist community QAnon has held that Trump is secretly saving the world from a pedophile cabal, its left-wing counterpart, derided as ‘BlueAnon,’ has posited the inverse.”

The language used on survivors and survivor-adjacent people is where the damage becomes easier to see. The article does not limit itself to saying that documentation is absent or that corroboration was not found as it spends page after page teaching the reader how to feel about the people around the account. The ex-wife is given space to call the recovered memories psychotic delusions, the family becomes a chorus of fear, exhaustion, disbelief, and collateral harm, the father is presented through tenderness, age, illness, adoption, photographs, and bewilderment and the funeral home becomes part of the moral architecture. By the time the article closes, **the story has been reorganized so that the principal public injury is not what might have happened in the past, or what can or cannot be proven now, but what belief itself is doing in the present.**

The article then starts doing secondary work as it stops being confined to the subject and starts speaking to the next person watching. **It tells every survivor, witness, relative, and frightened observer what public language is going to sound like if they cannot produce a perfect evidentiary package decades later.** They will not simply be doubted but their support networks will be reframed as cultic believers, their grief, instability, estrangement, and confusion will be brought forward as explanatory material, and their inability to prove everything at once will not sit at the edge of the story. **It will become the story.**

If the right-wing conspiracist community QAnon has held that Trump is secretly saving the world from a pedophile cabal, its left-wing counterpart, derided as “BlueAnon,” has posited the inverse: that the president is a serial child abuser. Those crimes will only be brought to light, this theory goes, by child victims who come forward and the online supporters who dare believe them.

The article does not merely reject the allegations. It relocates them into a category designed to discredit everyone standing near them.

✓ Subscribed

The article does not exist in a vacuum and neither does the subject and the timing of the article sharpens all of that. **Publishing days after Riley’s adoptive father died gave the piece a different temperature whether the writer acknowledged that or not. The story then made that death part of its own moral frame.** The father is not only interviewed, he is interviewed as a recovering old man who says he does not understand what he did to deserve this. Then he dies and the

funeral home is said to receive harassing emails and calls after Riley posts the obituary. None of that proves the allegations and none of it can be separated from how the piece guides the reader emotionally.

The subject of the article stops being a disputed abuse account and becomes, in part, the pain that follows from speaking it. That changes the entire distribution of sympathy inside the piece.

The article's treatment of Lisa Voldeng follows the same method and I was really hoping for more. It concedes ambiguity and then uses that ambiguity in one direction only as the reader is told that after two long phone calls the reporter could not say with confidence what Voldeng does.

That line could have opened a serious inquiry into why someone with so much rhetorical reach, so little institutional clarity, and so much sudden audience expansion was able to position herself around multiple abuse narratives at once.

Instead the article uses the strangeness mostly as atmosphere. There are woo-woo musings, superhero comics, ritual abuse references, and a fast move into the Satanic Panic frame. That history belongs in the record but so does the question the piece avoids with any force: **why a story that presents itself as skeptical is still willing to let a figure like Voldeng function as surreal scenery rather than as part of the mechanism that shaped public uptake in the first place. That is my issue with this piece, but it is also my job to expose Voldeng for who she is - and I am yet to share the worst parts of what she is.**

“After two hourlong phone calls with her, asking as many different ways as I knew how, I cannot say with confidence what Voldeng does.”



Lisa Noelle Voldeng

@lvoldeng

eternal. almighty. loves icecream and integrity.

The article acknowledges the scale of Voldeng's reach and then treats the architecture of that reach as atmosphere rather than as a reporting subject. The love icecream is something to pay attention to because it will be relevant in my future reporting.

Brandy Zadrozny's reporting trail is relevant here, not because biography settles an argument or because prior work disqualifies later work, but because **beats create habits**. In July 2016, while at The Daily Beast, Zadrozny wrote "*Trump Rape Accusers Turn On Each Other*," a piece centered less on the underlying allegation than on the breakdown, infighting, and instability around the people handling it. In October 2020, she and **Ben Collins** published a CNBC article about the Hunter Biden laptop information pipeline under the headline "*How a fake persona laid the groundwork for a Hunter Biden conspiracy deluge*." That piece traced provenance, fabrication, circulation, and the way a polluted information environment could prime the public for a larger politically useful story.

Put those earlier pieces next to the MS NOW article and a consistent professional instinct comes into view. **When a politically explosive allegation enters a dirty information environment, the reporting impulse is to track contamination, handlers, believers, and narrative spread.** That instinct can produce strong work but it can also become a way of stepping around the harder problem of what happens when the underlying allegation is old, traumatically fragmented, partially contaminated, socially combustible, and still not safely dismissible. **Under those conditions, the story of the claim is easier to manage than the claim itself.**

✓ Subscribed

Trump Rape Accusers Turn On Each Other

MY ENEMY'S ENEMY

Chaos is erupting among the motley crew who supported a woman's claims that Trump and billionaire pervert Jeffery Epstein raped her as a 13-year-old.



Brandy Zadrozny

Published Jul. 21 2016 11:38AM EDT



Getty/Zuma

The older reporting trail already shows where the lens goes when Trump-and-Epstein allegations become unstable.

How a fake persona laid the groundwork for a Hunter Biden conspiracy deluge

PUBLISHED THU, OCT 29 2020 7:23 PM EDT | UPDATED THU, OCT 29 2020 7:42 PM EDT

NBC NEWS Ben Collins, Brandy Zedrozny

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World Food Program USA Board Chairman Hunter Biden speaks at the World Food Program USA's Annual McGovern-Dole Leadership Award Ceremony at Organization of American States on April 12, 2016 in Washington, DC.

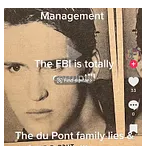
Paul Morigi / Getty Images

One month before a purported leak of files from Hunter Biden's laptop, a fake "intelligence" document about him went viral on the right-wing internet, asserting an elaborate conspiracy theory involving former Vice President Joe Biden's son and business in China.

The document, a 64-page composition that was later disseminated by close associates of President Donald Trump, appears to be the work of a fake "intelligence firm" called Typhoon Investigations, according to researchers and public documents.

Provenance, contamination, circulation, and story-shaping did not begin here. Below is an example of what real investigative reporting looks like. I just don't have the newsroom, legal team, or funding that mainstream media has and, yet, my work is close to changing the world. You will all see very soon.

That history becomes more interesting when set beside the **George Tonks** and **Ziegler** line I have already been documenting in this series. The Hunter Biden laptop story was never only about a device, as Zedrozny focused on in her reporting. It was about custody, mediation, timing, authentication theater, selective release, and the strategic value of contamination itself. Once a record is dirty enough, **anyone can step in later, gesture at the chaos, and declare the whole field too compromised to trust.** That posture sounds cautious and, in practice, **it often rewards the same people who benefit from confusion.** The old record stays polluted, the underlying actors remain partially obscured, and the audience is taught to distrust the entire zone. What I see in the MS NOW piece is not the same story, but it relies on a familiar method. **The account is introduced through extremity, the supporters are introduced through type, and the ecosystem around the claim becomes more legible than the incentives of the people who shaped that ecosystem.**



PART XVIII OF THE MACHINE: THE BOY FROM ALTAMONT

TROY BARILE • MAR 28

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The laptop story was never only about content. It was also about custody, contamination, and who benefited from the resulting fog. I broke this story and, again, I do not have the resources Brandy does.



The Woman in the Middle

TROY BARILE • MAR 11

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Read the MS NOW article beside the existing Lisa Voldeng record, not in place of it.

✓ **Subscribed**

Public career writeups describe Zadrozny as having worked earlier in research roles at ABC News and **Fox News** before The Daily Beast and NBC/MS NOW. Standing alone, that would not do much but the broader media ecology around those institutions does. Fox defended Tucker Carlson in court by arguing that no reasonable viewer would take his statements as factual reporting and then paid Dominion \$787.5 million to settle the election-defamation case and continues to face Smartmatic's separate suit after a New York appeals court allowed that case to proceed against Fox Corp. Those facts do not collapse into this article and they do not need to. They locate the article inside an American media world that is entirely comfortable shifting between fact, format, performance, and protection depending on who benefits from the classification. **The same industry that tells audiences to consume prime-time hyperbole skeptically also produces long reported features that use tone and structure to instruct skepticism toward damaged people long before any reader has seen the whole documentary field for themselves.**



Brandy Zadrozny ✓ · 3rd
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Brooklyn, New York, United States · [Contact info](#)
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**Senior Reporter**
NBC News
Mar 2018 - Jul 2025 · 7 yrs 5 mos
New York City Metropolitan Area

**Reporter / Senior Researcher**
The Daily Beast
May 2013 - Mar 2018 · 4 yrs 11 mos
New York City Metropolitan Area

**News Librarian / Researcher**
Fox News Channel
Dec 2011 - May 2013 · 1 yr 6 mos

Reporting habits do not emerge in a vacuum.

After \$787.5m Dominion settlement, what's next for Fox?

19 April 2023

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Bernd Debusmann Jr
BBC News, Washington



American media institutions have spent years litigating the boundary between reporting, performance, and protected hyperbole.

✓ Subscribed

That is why this article feeds back into the machine whether the writer intended it to or not. The machine does not require every participant to lie or coordination at every level. It benefits whenever attention is redirected from structure to spectacle, from institutions to believers, from the unanswered question of who profits from narrative management to the easier question of why damaged people say impossible things. It benefits when support networks can be portrayed as pathology, when public skepticism becomes indiscriminate and the evidentiary burden is applied hardest to the least powerful person in the room, and when **the terms of engagement are set so early that the rest of the record can only arrive inside them.**

What the MS NOW piece leaves behind is not only Sascha Riley but also the people who are not named in it but are watching it closely. The survivor who has no documents, the relative who knows something was wrong but cannot prove the shape of it, the witness who kept quiet because the wrong people were already orbiting the story, and even the person whose memory is ugly, delayed, unstable, socially inconvenient, or easy to caricature. Those people do not read a piece like this as an abstract exercise in skeptical reporting. They read it as instruction, a preview of how quickly a disputed account can be converted into a referendum on everyone standing nearby, and the saddest truth, as a warning about the cost of entering public language without institutional protection.

The article is one story about one subject, but it is also one more lesson in how narrative enforcement works when the record is damaged and power has every reason to keep it that way.

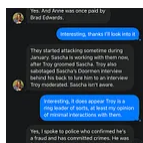
Troy Barile

PART XXI OF THE MACHINE: THE WOMAN WHO THOUGHT SHE COULD OWN THE STORY

Lisa Voldeng didn't lose credibility because people were mean. She lost it because the record caught up: The vault, the missing proof, the moderator mask, the paywall fight, the lies, and so much more



TROY BARILE
APR 03, 2026

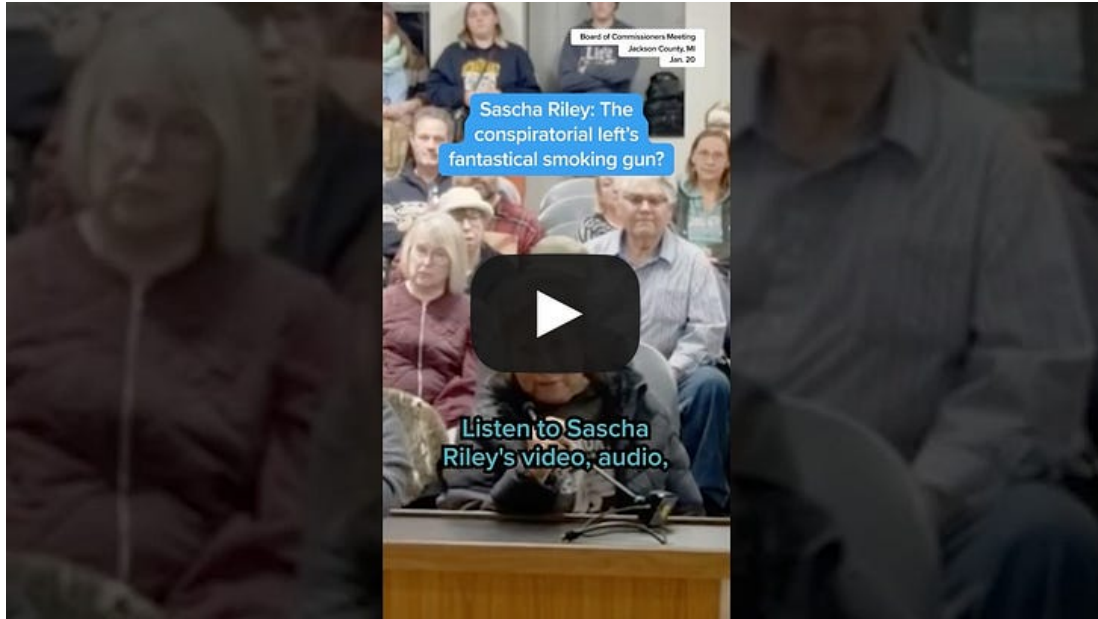


PART XXI OF THE MACHINE: THE WOMAN WHO THOUGHT SHE COULD OWN THE STORY

TROY BARILE • APR 4

[Read full story](#)

A damaged record can still be managed, packaged, and turned against the people standing nearest to it. That is what this kind of coverage teaches the public to accept.



✓ Subscribed

Congressional contact tool: grifter-nation.com

Troy Barile: thegrifter.nation@gmail.com

Crisis Resources: grifter-nation.help

***The Machine Investigative Workbook and Companion Website:
followthefiles.com***

As always, this reporting remains free. Paid subscriptions and Buy Me a Coffee support help cover records, research tools, and document costs, but there is no obligation.

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Troy Barile — The Fallout with TBS

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"The moment you publish something you cannot source, you've handed the people you are investigating a weapon they will use against you."

— FROM THE WORKBOOK, CHAPTER 1

Since The Machine series started, the most common thing in my inbox isn't a tip or a document — it's a question. Some version of: where do you look, how do you know what's real, how do you document something in a way that holds up when the people you're writing about have lawyers and you don't. I've answered it in DMs more times than I can count so this the answer and it's available to everyone.